Chapter Seven

The IDF Offensive

"We should prepare to go over to the offensive."

—David Ben-Gurion

Count Bernadotte had proposed an extension of the truce beyond July 9. King Abdullah I of Jordan was a supporter of this idea—as far as he was concerned, the Arab Legion had achieved its war aims by taking control of Jerusalem and occupying some Palestinian territory. Some military leaders within the other Arab armies were also supportive of extending the truce, mainly because it had proved difficult to resupply and reinforce their armies, which were at the end of extended supply routes. Israel, with shorter and internal supply routes, had no such problems, and some Arab military leaders were concerned that, if fighting resumed, they would find themselves at a disadvantage.

On July 8, discussions on extending the truce were brought to an abrupt end when Egyptian forces mounted a large-scale attack on the kibbutz at Negba, which covered the vital Majdal-Bayt Jibrin road. Negba had already been attacked by Egyptian forces during the first phase of the war, but they had failed to occupy the tiny hamlet. Now, the day before the ceasefire formally ended, a reinforced Egyptian brigade mounted a full-scale surprise assault on Negba supported by tanks, artillery, and aircraft.

The battle for control of Negba raged for three days until Egyptian forces were finally forced to withdraw after suffering over 300 casualties (the defenders lost only 20 in comparison). Although Egyptian forces made a number of subsequent efforts to surround and cut off Negba, they were not able to achieve this goal, and most of this second phase of the war (often called the Ten-Day Battles) was characterized by a number of IDF attacks.

The largest single IDF attack was Operation Danny, aimed at territory occupied by the Arab Legion. This offensive began on July